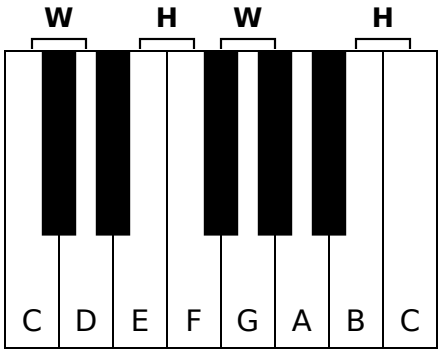
# Half Steps, Whole Steps, and Accidentals

A **half step** is the closest distance between two keys: from one key to the very next key, black or white. A **whole step** is two half steps, with exactly one key between the two keys. Most neighboring white keys have a black key between them, so they are a whole step apart. E to F and B to C have no black key between them, so they are half steps.

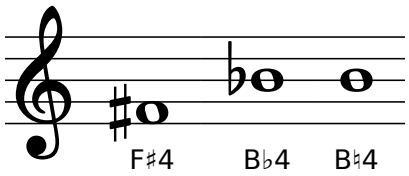



W = whole step, H = half step

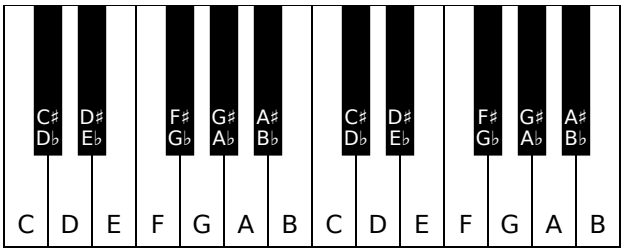
## Sharps, flats, and naturals

An **accidental** is a symbol placed before a note to change its pitch.

- A **sharp** (♯) raises a note by a half step.
- A **flat** (♭) lowers a note by a half step.
- A **natural** (♮) cancels a sharp or flat.



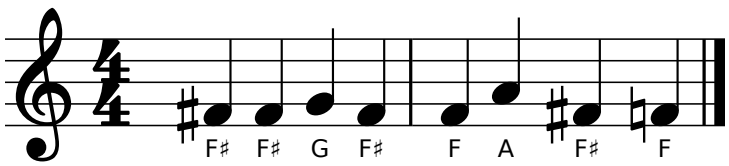

Each black key has two names. The black key between C and D is C♯ (C raised) and also D♭ (D lowered). Two names for the same key are **enharmonic equivalents**. A few white keys also have second names, because no black key lies between them: E♯ is F, B♯ is C, F♭ is E, and C♭ is B.




Each black key shows its sharp name above its flat name.

## Writing accidentals

An accidental is written immediately before the notehead, on the same line or space. It applies to that note and to every later note on the same line or space for the rest of the measure. A bar line cancels it. A natural sign cancels it within the measure.



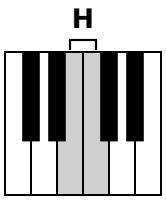

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Name _____ Date _____

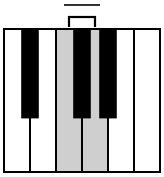
# Half Steps, Whole Steps, and Accidentals

**A. Half step or whole step** Write H (half step) or W (whole step) on the line above each pair of shaded keys.

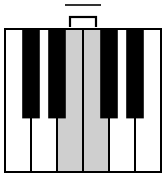
**EXAMPLE**



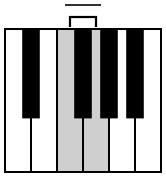

1.



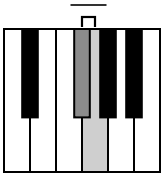
2.



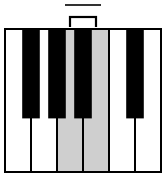
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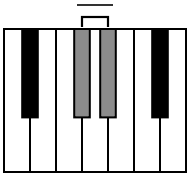
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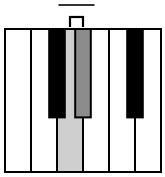
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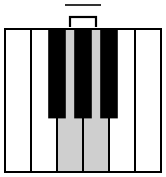
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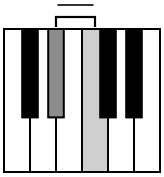
7.



8.



9.



**B. Sharps and flats** Name the note a half step above (sharp) or below (flat) each white key.

**EXAMPLE** Sharp of C: C♯

1. Flat of D: _____
2. Sharp of D: _____
3. Flat of E: _____
4. Sharp of F: _____
5. Flat of G: _____
6. Sharp of G: _____
7. Flat of A: _____
8. Sharp of A: _____
9. Flat of B: _____

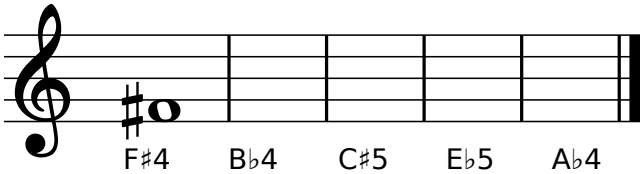
**C. Enharmonic equivalents** Write the other name for each black key.

**EXAMPLE** C♯ = D♭

1. D♯ = _____
2. F♯ = _____
3. G♯ = _____
4. A♯ = _____
5. D♭ = _____
6. E♭ = _____
7. G♭ = _____
8. A♭ = _____
9. B♭ = _____
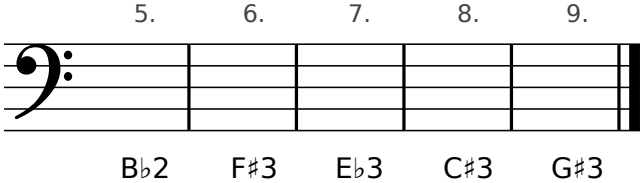
**D. Write notes with accidentals** Write each note as a whole note, with its accidental, in the clef shown.

**EXAMPLE** 1. 2. 3. 4.



F♯4 B♭4 C♯5 E♭5 A♭4

5. 6. 7. 8. 9.



B♭2 F♯3 E♭3 C♯3 G♯3

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